

feel I can do everything on court, to be honest: slices, drop shots, topspin, flat," he confidently declared.

SABALENKA STOPS ANISIMOVA FOR SECOND U.S. OPEN TITLE

A split second after Amanda Anisimova's return of serve sailed out on championship point, Aryna Sabalenka (**right**) went down on her knees, covered her eyes, and shed a few tears. The Queen of Hard Courts had defended her crown.

The poignant reaction spelled relief — as much as redemption and revenge — following her heartbreaking, three-set losses to Americans in the previous three Majors. In the Australian Open final, 22-1 long shot Madison Keys played lights-out power tennis to dethrone Sabalenka. Ghosts of past self-inflicted calamities reappeared in the Roland Garros final. Once again, Sabalenka couldn't control her shots or emotions, committing an ungodly 70 unforced errors, and succumbing to an inspired Coco Gauff. At Wimbledon, Anisimova, who had lost in the qualifying event a year ago, proved braver on the big points — Sabalenka converted just 3 of 14 break points — in a semifinal shocker.

"I want to prove to myself I learned tough lessons," Sabalenka said before the U.S. Open final. Win or lose, she would stay No. 1, but the measure of greatness is Grand Slam titles and Olympic gold medals, not elite-level consistency and season-ending rankings. The Belarusian superstar had a score to settle against the American who boasted a 6-3 head-to-head edge in their budding rivalry. **And if Sabalenka needed any more incentive, the winner would collect a cool \$5 million, the largest payday in Grand Slam history.**

Before their riveting semifinals, Sabalenka had the easier draw. She faced only one seed, No. 31 Leylah Fernandez, the undersized (5'4") Canadian lefty who upset her in the 2021 U.S. Open semis. This time Sabalenka prevailed 6-3, 7-6(2). Sabalenka lucked out when she reached the quarterfinals thanks to a

